Real cases about license plate readers

Thirteen events from courts, cities and the news. Each one has what happened, why it matters in Sun Prairie, and a question to discuss. Accounts come from the linked reports, and where they are disputed the card says so. Facts are as of Nov. 5, 2026.

How to use this packet. Give each pair one case. Have them read it, answer the question in two sentences, and tell the class one thing the story does not say.

COURT

Norfolk, Virginia: a judge says nearly 200 cameras are legal

What happened

Two Hampton Roads residents, represented by the Institute for Justice, sued the city. They argued that Norfolk’s network of nearly 200 Flock cameras violates the Fourth Amendment. In late January 2026 a federal judge sided with the city. He said other courts have almost uniformly found that photographing a plate on a public road, and keeping and searching a database of those photos, is not a warrantless search. He also noted that the technology is evolving and the balance could change. The plaintiffs said they planned to appeal. Check for newer news, because that was reported before any appeal.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

“Is it legal?” and “is it a good idea?” are different questions. A court can say a program is allowed while a city still chooses to set tighter limits than the law requires.

Talk about it

If a court says plate readers are legal, who should decide what limits Sun Prairie sets, and how?

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Source: WTKR, Jan. 27, 2026
(https://www.wtkr.com/news/in-the-community/norfolk/federal-judge-sides-with-city-of-norfolk-in-flock-camera-lawsuit)

AUDIT

Illinois: a state audit asks who the data was shared with

What happened

A 2023 Illinois law bars plate reader operators from sharing data to enforce immigration or abortion laws. The Secretary of State’s office audited Flock after the Texas search (next card) and alleged that Flock gave U.S. Customs and Border Protection access to Illinois data through a pilot program, and that Flock had no safeguards against out-of-state police breaking the law. Flock disagreed with the legal claims. Its CEO wrote, “We clearly communicated poorly,” and said Flock had paused all pilots with federal agencies. The article notes the Illinois law has no specific penalties.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

A rule against sharing only matters if someone checks that it is followed. An audit is how a promise becomes something you can verify.

Talk about it

Who would check that Sun Prairie’s data-sharing promises are being kept, and how would the public find out?

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Source: Capitol News Illinois via NPR Illinois, Aug. 27, 2025 (https://www.nprillinois.org/illinois/2025-08-27/hundreds-of-police-departments-use-camera-company-accused-of-breaking-state-law)

SEARCH LOG

Texas: one search, two accounts of why

What happened

The Electronic Frontier Foundation reported that in May 2025 a Texas sheriff’s office searched Flock networks across the country for a woman who had an abortion. The reason typed into the search log read “had an abortion, search for female.” The sheriff said deputies were checking on her welfare because her family feared she would bleed to death, and that she was never under investigation. Flock called the claim that the search was about the abortion “unequivocally false” and said she was searched for as a missing person. EFF said court records showed a “death investigation.” These accounts disagree, and this page does not decide between them.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

The person searching types the reason, and that reason is what an audit later reads. A log is only as useful as the rules about what a reason must say and who reviews it.

Talk about it

What should a search reason have to include, and who should read them?

Source: EFF, Oct. 7, 2025 (https://www.eff.org/deeplinks/2025/10/flock-safety-and-texas-sheriff-claimed-license-plate-search-was-missing-person-it)

CONTRACT

Evanston: ending a contract is not the same as the cameras leaving

What happened

Evanston ended its Flock contract in August 2025, citing the Illinois audit and Flock's admission about the federal pilot, deactivated its cameras, and issued a termination notice effective Sept. 26, 2025. Flock's chief legal officer called it a "communication error" that has been fixed. A month later, according to Ban The Cams! (an advocacy group summarizing the Evanston RoundTable), Flock reinstalled cameras without permission and the city sent a cease-and-desist letter. The same source says Flock was challenging the termination and that the city faced potential liability of $145,500.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

The exit terms of a contract decide what happens when a city wants out: who removes the cameras, how fast, and who pays.

Talk about it

What should Sun Prairie's contract say about removing cameras and deleting data if the city ends it?

Source: ABC 7 Chicago, Aug. 29, 2025 (https://abc7chicago.com/post/evanston-oak-park-end-contracts-flock-safety-license-plate-reader-company-investigation-illinois/17678137/) · Ban The Cams!, Sept. 25, 2025 (an advocacy group summarizing the Evanston RoundTable) (https://banthecams.org/posts/2025/09/25/evanston-issues-cease-and-desist-to-flock-over-camera-reinstall)

PILOT

Austin: a pilot that was almost extended without end

What happened

In June 2025 Austin’s city manager pulled a proposal to extend the police plate reader pilot indefinitely, after negative public reaction. Dozens of residents spoke against it, and opponents raised concerns about Flock’s contract allowing data sharing with private sources and federal agencies. Police leaders said the cameras helped solve dozens of cases and were used properly. Police use of Flock’s fixed cameras, and of plate readers in more than 500 police vehicles under separate Axon contracts, was to be shut off at the end of June 2025, and the Flock extension could return to the council later.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

A “pilot” can quietly turn into a permanent program. Sun Prairie’s Axon plan starts with a three-month trial, so the question of what happens at the end of it matters.

Talk about it

What would count as a successful three-month trial, and who decides whether it continues?

Source: Community Impact, June 4, 2025 (https://communityimpact.com/austin/south-central-austin/government/2025/06/04/austin-to-halt-police-license-plate-reader-program-after-public-pushback)

LAW

Virginia: the state sets a 21-day limit

What happened

Virginia’s 2025 law caps how long law enforcement can keep plate reader data at 21 days. The governor had recommended 30 days, but House lawmakers rejected that change 47 to 46, and he signed the bill as passed. State Police use of readers on state highways, bridges and tunnels needed the General Assembly’s approval again in the 2026 session.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

When a state sets a rule, every city has the same floor. As far as I can tell Wisconsin does not have a state plate reader law yet. Its attorney general has called for one. See the Wisconsin section below.

Talk about it

Should retention be decided by the state, by each city, or by each contract?

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Source: Land Line, Aug. 8, 2025 (https://landline.media/more-states-adopt-rules-on-license-plate-readers/)

COUNCIL

Oshkosh: the council changed its mind in a day

What happened

Oshkosh’s council backed Flock and then reversed itself the next day. The police chief said officials were misled about what the system could do and that he could no longer recommend it. This is the account on the Compare tab.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

Votes can move fast when new information comes out. Residents who ask questions before a vote can change what the council knows.

Talk about it

What would you want the council to know before it votes on a contract?

Source: The Compare tab at sunprairiealpr.netlify.app

REMOVAL

Henrico County, Virginia: the county pulled the cameras itself

What happened

Henrico ended its Flock contract over data-collection, data-access and privacy concerns. Flock was given until Oct. 21 to remove the cameras and did not, so county crews took down more than 120 of them on Oct. 31. Flock says it would have complied and is coordinating the rest of the removal.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

Who owns the poles, the cameras and the data after a contract ends is a question to settle before signing.

Talk about it

If Flock or Axon missed a deadline in Sun Prairie, what would the contract let the city do?

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Source: WTVR, Nov. 2, 2026 (https://wtvr.com/news/local-news/henrico-county/henrico-removes-flock-cameras-nov-2-2026)

CONTRACT

Cedar Rapids: a 164-page contract and a decade-long plan

What happened

Cedar Rapids is phasing out more than 70 Flock cameras and using Axon plate readers. The contract runs 164 pages and budgets for 20 Axon Outpost cameras. Data is held for 30 days unless it is part of an active investigation. KCRG cites a $14 million agreement with Axon announced in August and a $14.6 million public safety investment the council approved in June for a decade-long contract.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

Most of the rules live in the contract, and the contract is long. Reading it, or at least asking for the key terms in writing, is part of knowing what a city agreed to.

Talk about it

Which five pages of a 164-page contract would you read first, and why?

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Source: KCRG, Nov. 2, 2026
(https://www.kcrg.com/2026/11/02/cedar-rapids-police-start-using-axon-license-plate-readers/)

BALLOT

York, Maine: voters decide directly

What happened

York put a question on the ballot asking whether to ban automatic license plate readers, including Flock's. Voters approved it, and the town must remove or shut off its Flock cameras and end the contract. Police said the cameras helped in investigations, and residents raised privacy concerns. The article does not give the vote count.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

Some places let voters decide a question directly. Wisconsin cities can ask voters an advisory question, which tells officials what residents think but does not bind them.

Talk about it

Should a plate reader decision go to voters, or to the council? What are the tradeoffs?

Source: Fox 23 Maine, Nov. 4, 2026 (https://fox23maine.com/news/local/york-voters-approve-ban-on-flock-license-plate-cameras-maine-crime-ai-artificial-intelligence-privacy-concerns)

ORDINANCE

Bloomington, Indiana: a unanimous ban, then the mayor

What happened

Bloomington’s council voted unanimously to ban plate readers and shared third-party cameras. The ordinance goes to the mayor, and a two-thirds council vote could override a veto. Park closed-circuit cameras and police body cameras are exempt. The city’s 11 plate-reader cameras were already removed, and local police said Flock cameras had helped solve crimes.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

An ordinance is a local law with steps: committee, council vote, mayor. Knowing the steps tells you when your voice counts most.

Talk about it

At which step would you contact an alder in Sun Prairie, and what would you ask?

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Source: WFIU, Oct. 15, 2026
(https://www.ipm.org/news/2026-10-15/city-council-nixes-automated-license-plate-readers)

CLAIMS

A claim to test: “it would have helped in a homicide”

What happened

Sun Prairie’s Assistant Chief called the cameras “an immediate force multiplier” and said cameras along the east corridor would have helped investigators in an October 2024 homicide. That is his claim in a news interview.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

A claim can be sincere and still need evidence. A good question is not “is that true?” but “what would we need to see to test it?”

Talk about it

What numbers would test the claim? For example: how many cases, how many were solved, and how many would have been solved anyway.

Source: WMTV 15, Nov. 2025 (https://www.wmtv15news.com/2025/11/24/sun-prairie-pd-automatic-license-plate-readers-concern-some-residents)

MONEY

Flock’s lobbying in Wisconsin

What happened

The Wisconsin Examiner reported that Flock spent about $102,000 in 2025 lobbying for two Wisconsin bills, AB 300 and SB 299, that would have provided grants for local plate readers. Neither passed.

Why it matters in Sun Prairie

Companies lobby, as many do, and that is legal and public. Knowing who is trying to influence a decision is part of understanding it.

Talk about it

Who else is trying to influence this decision, and how would you find out?

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Source: Wisconsin Examiner via Urban Milwaukee, Aug. 30, 2026 (https://urbanmilwaukee.com/2026/08/30/flock-lobbyists-flocking-to-state-capitols/)

A timeline, 2023 to now

2023. Illinois passes a law barring plate reader data from being shared to enforce immigration or abortion laws. (Capitol News Illinois via NPR Illinois, Aug. 27, 2025)

May 2025. A Texas sheriff's office searches Flock networks nationwide for a woman who had an abortion. The account of why is disputed. (EFF, Oct. 7, 2025)

June 2025. Austin's city manager pulls a proposal to extend the police plate reader pilot indefinitely. (Community Impact, June 4, 2025)

Aug. 2025. Oak Park and Evanston end their Flock contracts. Flock says it has paused pilots with federal agencies. (ABC 7 Chicago, Aug. 29, 2025)

Aug. 2025. Virginia's 21-day retention law is reported as signed. (Land Line, Aug. 8, 2025)

Sept. 2025. Evanston sends Flock a cease-and-desist letter after cameras are reinstalled. (Ban The Cams!, Sept. 25, 2025 (an advocacy group summarizing the Evanston RoundTable))

Nov. 2025. Local coverage of Sun Prairie police plate readers and resident concerns. (WMTV 15, Nov. 2025)

Jan. 2026. A federal judge sides with Norfolk in the Fourth Amendment challenge. Plaintiffs say they will appeal. (WTKR, Jan. 27, 2026)

Aug. 2026. The Wisconsin Examiner reports on Flock's lobbying and lists Wisconsin places that cancelled. (Wisconsin Examiner via Urban Milwaukee, Aug. 30, 2026)

Sept. 2026. Wisconsin's attorney general calls for a state law on plate readers. Racine County and five Fond du Lac County agencies move to end Flock agreements. (CBS 58, Sept. 8, 2026)

Oct. 2026. Bloomington's council votes unanimously to ban plate readers. Sun Prairie's Public Safety Committee hears the Chief's report (Oct. 7). (WFIU, Oct. 15, 2026)

Nov. 2026. York voters approve a ban. Henrico removes 120+ cameras. Cedar Rapids starts using Axon. (Fox 23 Maine, Nov. 4, 2026)